

Japanese Tree Lilac

Syringa reticulata



Origin

Native to Japan, Korea, and parts of northern China; despite its common name, it's a true member of the lilac genus (*Syringa*), grown as a small tree rather than a shrub.

Look for

It's the only true tree-sized member of the lilac group commonly planted on city streets -- most other lilacs are large shrubs, not trees, which is what makes this one useful as a small street tree.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Flower: large creamy-white clusters in early summer, later than shrub lilacs.
- Bark: smooth, cherry-like, with horizontal lenticels.
- Growth form: a true tree, unlike most lilacs which grow as shrubs.
- Commonly confused with: ordinary cherry trees (bark looks similar, but this tree's flower clusters are much larger and creamy white, not pink).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Smooth, pointed leaves emerge on a small, tidy crown.
Summer	Large clusters of creamy white flowers bloom in early summer, later than most lilac shrubs.
Fall	Leaves turn an unremarkable yellow-green.
Winter	Smooth, cherry-like bark with horizontal lenticels stands out on bare branches.

DID YOU KNOW

- Its flowers bloom later in early summer than shrub lilacs, extending the lilac-flowering season by several weeks in a city planted with both.
- Its smooth bark with horizontal lenticels closely resembles cherry tree bark, which is a common source of misidentification.